



Intelligence gathering

Members of a US Army Long Range Reconnaissance Patrol (LRRP) prepare to set out on patrol during Operation Junction City. LRRP teams collected intelligence on the movement of communist fighters and coordinated artillery and air strikes.

Battle phase

The second stage of Junction City began in mid-March, when US forces set up Katum Special Forces camp and fire support bases to establish a more permanent American presence in the region. During this phase of the operation, Viet Cong forces mounted substantial resistance, especially on the grounds of a former rubber plantation. These battles forged a pattern, in which the Viet Cong launched deadly assaults against US forces, who beat them back with overwhelming firepower, inflicting heavy casualties. For example, fighting at the fire support base near Ap Bau Bang resulted in three Americans killed and 60 wounded, while 227 Viet Cong fighters were found on the battlefield when dawn broke.

Boosting morale

Overall, Junction City had mixed success. The airborne assault was spectacular, making for dramatic headlines on the home front and boosting the morale of US troops in Vietnam. However, the Viet Cong did not behave as anticipated. For the most part, the guerrilla fighters hid or retreated across the border into Cambodia, whose neutrality prohibited US forces from following. Although US forces discovered a cache of enemy propaganda suggesting that a component of COSVN was active in the region, the organization as a whole was neither discovered nor seriously compromised by the operation.

Junction City's most significant contribution to the American war effort was its body count. While US forces lost 282 dead in 11 weeks of fighting, the Viet Cong lost perhaps 10 times as many fighters. And yet, it made little difference in their ability to wage war against